



NORTH NORFOLK ENGLAND

Great Pub Grub in North Norfolk

The pubs along North Norfolk's windswept coast have long been cozy refuges, but these days they offer more than just a pint to warm your cockles. Old-fashioned drinking dens have been transformed into gastropubs, where you are now likely to be greeted by the delicious aroma of pan-fried scallops or duck with lavender sauce, served with real ale or a good choice of wines.



The famously flat North Norfolk landscape has a haunting atmosphere all its own, with sand dunes and saltmarshes stretching for miles along the shore.

Tidal mudflats attract rare migratory birds, and colonies of seals inhabit the sandbars offshore. Popular in summer for seaside excursions and seal-spotting trips, the coastline's very bleakness draws visitors for birdwatching and bracing walks in winter. And once the fresh sea air has brought a rosy glow to your cheeks, there's nothing like ducking into a gastropub – one of the new breed of “dining pubs” dedicated to fine, locally sourced food – for a hearty meal.

All along the North Norfolk coast you'll find historic stone-walled pubs that are now gastropubs. In summer, vacationers breeze in from the beaches, while in winter, roaring wood fires and steaming damp dogs help build up a convivial fug in which locals gather in snug settles polished smooth by use – much as they have done for the last 500 years. At the Lord Nelson in Burnham Thorpe, you can draw your chair up to the hearth where the Admiral himself warmed his feet. And while you soak up the atmosphere, you can also sample the fruits of the sea and surrounding farmlands.

The fertile fields and grazing marshes support prime beef, lamb, and pork – and prime sausages in rich onion sauce are a gastropub staple. Game is a Norfolk specialty, too: pheasant, partridge, and pigeon abound in season. Pedigree incarnations of classic dishes, such as Sandringham Red Poll rib-eye steak – a rare breed that hit the headlines during a spate of cattle-rustling from the Queen's estate – or local game stew with thyme dumplings are enough to make the mouth of any carnivore water. But seafood is what the region is all about. The sea, the sands, and the winding saltmarsh creeks yield Stiffkey Blue cockles, Thornham mussels and oysters, Brancaster lobster, Cromer crabs, and fresh-caught North Sea fish. Samphire, a succulent marsh grass, is the perfect accompaniment, lightly steamed and salty.

Reinvigorated by a gastropub lunch, you might choose to visit 18th-century Holkham Hall, a Palladian masterpiece with impressive grounds; explore the picturesque villages of Blakeney and Cley next the Sea; enjoy British seaside fun in the brasher resorts of Wells next the Sea and Cromer; venture inland to the pretty towns of Burnham Market or Holt – or simply continue walking along the dreamy, timeless Norfolk coastal path, pausing to investigate the tide pools along the way.

Three Days in North Norfolk

It's less than 40 miles (65 km) from Hunstanton to Cromer, but between these two busy seaside resorts are plenty of delightful stopping-off points – and gastropubs.

DAY ONE Enjoy **Hunstanton**, with its fairground, promenade, and all the fun of the typical vacation resort. Visit the Queen's country home at **Sandringham House**, open to visitors most of the summer. In between the two is **Norfolk Lavender**, a lavender farm and visitor attraction where in summer the scent of these lovely plants fills the air.

DAY TWO Linger in the village of **Brancaster**, with its beach and nature preserve, before heading inland to **Burnham Market**, an attractive town with excellent shopping and dining, ideal for lunch. Nearby is **Holkham Hall**, a country house worth touring before taking the coast road to enjoy **Wells next the Sea** and **Blakeney**.

DAY THREE In Blakeney, book a boat trip to see the **seal colony**, before visiting nearby **Cley next the Sea**, a pretty village known for its pottery and fish smokery. Head east for an afternoon in the adjacent resorts of **Sheringham** or **Cromer**.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

King's Lynn and Cromer can be reached by **rail** from London and from Norwich, and **buses** run regularly up and down the coast.

WHERE TO STAY

The Gin Trap Inn (moderate) in Ringstead is a gastropub with lovely views from the bedrooms. www.gintrapinn.co.uk

The Neptune (moderate) has a Michelin-starred restaurant. www.theneptune.co.uk

Byfords (expensive), Holt's oldest building, is now a fun boutique hotel. www.byfords.org.uk

TOURIST INFORMATION

Staithe Street, Wells next the Sea.

